Animal Planning

Plan for every animal before an alert. Identify who will move each animal, what they need, where they can go, and what happens if normal transport is not possible.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Act early for livestock: loading and moving large animals takes time, trained handlers, suitable vehicles, and a confirmed destination. Follow current instructions from local emergency management, animal control, agricultural extension, and your veterinarian. Do not enter a threatened area or delay your own evacuation to move an animal.

PREPARE EVERY ANIMAL

- ☐ Use permanent identification when appropriate; add a securely attached temporary contact label. Keep current photos showing the animal and its identifying features, including a photo with the owner or handler.
- ☐ Protect copies of veterinary, vaccination, prescription, registration, microchip, ownership, and any health-certificate records. Keep veterinarian and poison-control contact information with them.
- ☐ Pack current medications, written dosing and care instructions, and needed administration supplies. Ask the veterinarian how to manage medicines requiring refrigeration.
- ☐ Rotate animal food and drinking water; pack bowls or feeders, a manual can opener if needed, and species-appropriate sanitation supplies.
- ☐ Practice calm confinement and loading with the carrier, crate, leash, harness, halter, or other restraint the animal will actually use.
- ☐ Name a primary and backup caregiver. Give each person written permission, access instructions, the animal inventory, and a way to reach the veterinarian.
- ☐ Confirm more than one evacuation destination and route. Ask each destination what species it accepts, what records or equipment it requires, and whether owner and animal can remain together.

Do not assume a public shelter, hotel, boarding facility, fairground, or rescue site will accept an animal. Rules, capacity, opening times, and health requirements vary and can change during an incident. Verify them locally before leaving and again when officials activate evacuation or shelter sites.

Animal Planning — continued

HOUSEHOLD PETS

- ☐ Assign one carrier or safe restraint to each pet; label it with animal and household contact information.
- ☐ Pack litter and a pan, waste bags, cleaning supplies, familiar bedding, and species-specific heat, light, habitat, or handling equipment.
- ☐ Identify pet-friendly lodging, boarding, friends or relatives, and any locally designated animal sheltering. Keep an option outside the immediate hazard area.
- ☐ Plan for frightened or hiding pets: record likely hiding places and keep safe capture tools where they are accessible.

SERVICE ANIMALS

A service animal is not a pet. Keep the animal with its handler whenever possible and include its work and access needs in the household plan.

- ☐ Pack food, water, medicines, sanitation supplies, a leash or harness, and any gear needed for the animal's work. Do not separate the animal from the handler's essential mobility, communication, medical, or power equipment.
- ☐ Plan accessible transport with enough space for the handler, animal, mobility device, and supplies. Arrange an accessible backup vehicle and driver.
- ☐ Record the animal's tasks, commands, routine, stress signals, and care instructions in case a backup caregiver must assist.
- ☐ Verify current shelter and transport arrangements with local officials. Under the ADA, service animals generally accompany people with disabilities in public facilities; different rules may apply to animals that provide comfort but are not trained to perform a disability-related task.

Animal Planning — continued

LIVESTOCK AND OTHER LARGE ANIMALS

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Use local, incident-specific direction: suitable routes, loading sites, movement controls, health documentation, shelter locations, and options for animals left in place depend on the hazard and jurisdiction. Generic advice cannot confirm that a road or facility is safe or open.

- ☐ Maintain a current herd or flock inventory. Record species, number, identification, photographs, usual location, ownership, veterinarian, and special handling or medical needs.
- ☐ Map gates, pens, pastures, barns, water shutoffs, feed, handling equipment, and vehicle access. Give the map and access information to caregivers.
- ☐ Keep species-appropriate halters, leads, panels, gates, cages, loading aids, and protective equipment ready and in working order.
- ☐ Confirm enough suitable towing vehicles, trailers, drivers, handlers, fuel, and accessible loading space. Practice loading before an emergency; never exceed equipment ratings.
- ☐ Set a loading order that accounts for temperament, compatibility, medical needs, young animals, and the time each group needs. Keep incompatible animals separated.
- ☐ Confirm destinations with the facility and local authorities. Ask about capacity, identification, health records, biosecurity, feed and water, sanitation, unloading, and who provides daily care.

IF NORMAL HOUSEHOLD TRANSPORT WILL NOT WORK

1. **Identify the gap now.** Note animals that are too large, numerous, difficult to handle, medically fragile, or unable to use the available vehicle or carrier.
2. **Arrange qualified help.** Make written primary and backup arrangements with trained caregivers, transporters, boarding facilities, neighbors, or mutual-aid partners. Confirm how they will gain access and who may authorize care.
3. **Set an early trigger.** Decide when to call and load—before roads, air quality, weather, staffing, or animal behavior make movement unsafe. Reconfirm the plan during high-risk periods.
4. **Plan a locally approved alternative.** Ask local emergency management, animal control, agricultural extension, and the veterinarian what to do if evacuation is impossible. Record only instructions verified for the location, species, and hazard; do not release animals or improvise an unsafe move.

Animal Planning — continued

⌖ **LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL**

Verify locally before an incident:

Emergency-management / evacuation instructions: [VERIFY] _____

Animal control / activated animal sheltering: [VERIFY] _____

Agricultural-extension contact and livestock guidance: [VERIFY] _____

Veterinarian / emergency veterinary service: [VERIFY] _____

Transporter and backup transporter: [VERIFY] _____

Related handouts: use **STH-001 — Emergency Preparedness Quick Start** for immediate priorities; **STH-002 — Build a Two-Week Preparedness Kit** for shared supplies; **STH-003 — Know Your Local Hazards** for local alerts and protective actions; and **STH-007 — Annual Binder & Kit Review** to keep this plan current. Follow the detailed animal plan on this handout when a general checklist differs.

Animal Planning — continued

ANIMAL INVENTORY AND EVACUATION WORKSHEET

Complete one row for each animal or clearly identified compatible group. Attach extra pages, photos, records, maps, and written care instructions. Update after any change.

Animal / group and species	Identification and current photo reference	Usual location	Handling considerations

Carrier, restraint, or handling equipment and location	Loading order	Confirmed destination and route

Animal Planning — continued

CARE AND BACKUP ARRANGEMENTS

Primary caregiver / handler: _____ **Phone:** _____

Access and written authorization: _____

Veterinarian / clinic: _____ **Phone:** _____

Primary transporter / vehicle / trailer: _____

Backup caregiver: _____ **Phone:** _____

Backup destination: _____

Backup transport and loading arrangement: _____

Plan for animals that cannot use normal household transport:

_____

_____

Early-action trigger: _____

Medication, food, water, sanitation, or accessibility notes:

_____

Last verified (date / by whom): _____

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Pets and Animals”; CDC Healthy Pets, Healthy People, “Emergency Preparedness”; U.S. Department of Justice Civil Rights Division, “Frequently Asked Questions about Service Animals and the ADA”; and USDA APHIS, “Animal Health Emergency Management.” Accessed 2026-09-25. Local evacuation, shelter, agricultural-extension, animal-control, and veterinary instructions must be verified for the incident and jurisdiction.